

Separating Art and Artist

On October 8th of this year, Kanye West tweeted, “The funny thing is I actually can’t be Anti Semitic because black people are actually Jew.” The Chicago rapper, now officially known as Ye, is no stranger to negative attention in the media. In fact, he practically invented it. Ye has made numerous rants and controversial statements in the past, which many tie to his diagnosed bipolar disorder. An early example is in 2005 when he appeared on a TV fundraiser for Hurricane Katrina victims alongside celebrity, Mike Myers (*Kanye West: George Bush Doesn’t Care about Black People*, 2007). To Mike’s visible confusion, West went entirely off-script to monologue about the portrayal of black versus white victims, capping it off with, “George Bush does not care about black people.” Many in the black community applauded Kanye for making such a bold statement on live television in defense of black victims in New Orleans. Unfortunately, his public outbursts became less justifiable over time.

In 2018, West made the news again for his public support of Donald Trump, seen multiple times wearing a red MAGA hat and meeting Trump himself in the Oval Office. Not long after this, he came out with the statement, “When you hear about slavery for 400 years ... For 400 years? That sounds like a choice.” (Kaur, 2018) This sent the internet into a frenzy, and despite Kanye’s efforts to rephrase the context of what he said, the damage had already been done. Kanye’s attacks on his own race felt like a slap in the face for those who looked to him to stand up for the black community. And yet despite making such an unthinkable statement, the public was still able to brush it aside as all part of a grand creative process beyond our understanding.

The next chapter of Ye’s public image brought confusion and even passive optimism. 2019 gave rise to the Sunday Service Choir, and West’s ninth studio album, *Jesus is King*. Religious symbolism and messages were nothing out of the ordinary in his past works, but this level of Christian zealotism was a surprise, especially as rapidly as it happened. Suddenly the artist who said, “I feel like me and Taylor might still have sex / Why? I made that bitch famous,” (West, 2016, 0:30) wouldn’t consider swearing in a song for fear of it not being “Christ-like.” This era of Kanye’s career gave his fans and passive onlookers a glimpse of hope that maybe he found the wrong in his past actions through religion, although his critics argued it was all just a ruse to generate positive publicity.

Any semblance of an upswing was squandered in February of 2021 when West’s wife of six years, Kim Kardashian, filed for divorce. She had endured more than enough of Kanye’s continuous outbursts and ever-changing personality and decided it would be best for the family. West didn’t take this well, resorting to Twitter to attack her and feud with her new boyfriend Pete Davidson. On top of this Kanye constantly brought his kids into the middle of the issue while publicly arguing to have custody over them. Despite all of this, West’s lowest point wouldn’t come until this October, when he tweeted:



This came after he posted a photo on Instagram wearing a shirt with the “White Lives Matter” slogan on the back. This was the last straw for many. Kanye was now left without his wife to defend him or help control his manic outbursts. West was relentlessly attacked for his anti-Semitism.

Kanye is used to facing this kind of hate, but for once his career is starting to go under because of it. On the 25th of October, Adidas officially ended its partnership with Ye, effectively destroying his famous Yeezy brand. This comprised such a large portion of his net worth that he lost his billionaire status. Many large celebrities also denounced Kanye such as Kim Kardashian, AOC, and Eric Andre who made the comment, “Do you really like Kanye’s music more than your own ethics and morals? Is music that f***ing special in general???? You’re that apathetic?!?!” (Andre, 2022)

That brings us to the driving question in all of this, how does this affect our perception of Kanye’s music career? Despite everything he’s done, it’s hard to deny the impact Kanye has had on not just Hip Hop, but the entire music industry. He popularized the use of heavy 808 beats with his fourth album, *808’s and Heartbreak*. He pioneered a method of sampling called “Chipmunk Soul” and is considered one of the most talented producers of all time for augmenting obscure audio clips into some of the most iconic and recognizable melodies of the 2000s. On top of everything, Ye has won 24 grammies and been nominated for 75.

Will listening to Kanye’s music benefit him directly? Yes, because he’ll gain the royalties from the streaming platform you’re using (assuming you’re listening legally). Will it fuel more outbursts and problematic rants? On a large scale, not really, outside of the small financial benefit he gains from your consumption of his works and maintaining his listening statistics. Is Kanye’s art imbued with the same messages he pronounces on Twitter? For the most part, no. Much of his music was made before his transgressions in recent years and his musical persona is largely detached from his manic ranting persona.

Keeping all of this in mind, the way forward becomes unclear. It likely means the way someone approaches Ye's music hinges on their stance before the drama. A Kanye fan will probably still listen to Kanye, disapproving of his comments while simultaneously detaching from his public image to still appreciate his past artistry. Past critics and apathetic onlookers on the other hand will probably continue to not listen to Kanye as their perception of him goes down the drain.

Kanye's entire situation is nothing more than an isolated incident of a larger trend recently involving famous artists and celebrities facing the force known as "cancel culture." An actor, athlete, or musician is accused of something, arrested, or makes a statement anywhere from a little too out there to downright racist, sexist, xenophobic, etc., and is subsequently "canceled" by the internet. Then the fans are left to wonder where they stand among the debris. Kyrie Irving of the Brooklyn Nets is one of the most talented basketball players currently active and is another public figure who was recently canceled. In a similar situation to Kanye with anti-Semitism, Irving's deal with Nike has been dropped, and he won't be allowed to return to play until he fulfills the Nets' demands regarding reconciliation. Also, like Kanye, Irving is no stranger to public controversy, the previous being his refusal to get the COVID-19 vaccine, which also barred him from playing.

Although their situations are extremely similar, the conversation around the consumption of their art differs greatly. Should a fan of Kyrie or the Nets not watch the game while he's on the court? It's unlikely someone is focused on his lack of vaccination as he crosses over twice into a reverse layup around three defenders, the same way someone isn't thinking about Kanye's support of Donald Trump while listening to "Flashing Lights." So what is the defining factor in the decision to consume the art of controversial or canceled artists? What hasn't been considered is the severity of their transgression. Another rapper, R. Kelly, was convicted of three counts of child pornography and two more of child enticement. The decision to stop consuming his art is an easy one in this case. Why would anyone want to be associated with a child abuser? While this doesn't minimize the actions of Kanye or Kyrie, it does lead us to a comparison of how we treat their images. There's little argument against the cancellation of R. Kelly, while there are clearly defined sides in the debate around Kanye and Kyrie. Because their actions are seen as less severe or taboo by some, more of an argument can be made to continue supporting their art. Another factor to consider is that few would likely argue R. Kelly's music has had the same artistic impact as Kanye's music or Kyrie's basketball talents, again making him an easier figure to drop.

Looking at these various case studies, we can derive questions to consider to better inform our personal decision of whether to separate a piece of art from its controversial artist. Each question descends in order of moral significance and is followed by examples of their application and clarification.

1. How bad was the act of the artist?

Do you agree with the media's assessment of the artist's transgressions? The worse the act of the artist in your mind, the harder it is to justify continued support of them in any form. This also involves weighing your own assessment of the situation against the

popular depiction of it. If public opinion is completely outraged while you take no issue, you should likely reconsider and do more research. For example, do you think the artist actually did what they were accused of, whether it be assault or racism, sexism, etc.?

2. Is the art imbued with the corrupt values in question?

In the case of Kanye, most of his music does not contain messages pertaining to anti-Semitism, or racism. Alternatively, YNW Melly made a song titled, "Murder on my Mind," the true meaning of which was later revealed to be referencing his two friends that he murdered in a drive-by shooting. (Hopkins, 2019)

3. How much inherent value does the art itself have?

Artistic works that are considered canonical or have had a massive impact on their respective field carry more weight than those with a much smaller following. Dismissing the works of someone like Stanley Kubrick is more difficult than a less impactful director such as J.J. Abrams because of Kubrick's hypercanonical status, even though they both carry a lot of fame.

4. Does consuming the art directly benefit the artist?

Listening to a song provides a very slight benefit to musical artists while seeing a concert is monetarily more significant. Watching a sports game on your TV has almost no impact on an individual player.

5. Were you already a fan?

If you were already a fan of the artist before they came under fire, it can be easier or much more convenient to defend them. In many cases, you'll likely continue to support them. You should take a step back from your own bias as a fan if this applies.

Ideally with the consideration of these questions, one should be able to determine whether they think consuming a piece of art is morally acceptable or not. In the situation of someone like Kanye or Kyrie there is no right or wrong answer to consuming their art. It's ultimately up to you to weigh the moral arguments of what they're accused of. Art is an inherently creative endeavor with many hidden meanings and layered complexities that is meant to be dissected. Whether that dissection results in cherishing or dismissing it, it should be protected as self-expression no matter what.

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